

Is this the beginning of the end?

Out of the hundreds of news feeds that make it into my inbox, one seemingly innocuous item last month just seemed to jump right out at me. There wasn't anything particularly insidious about it, and it certainly wasn't the sensational "India bans porn" headline that sent everyone and their uncles (literally) into a tizzy. No, this was truly low key. It was a news report announcing the successful deployment of NEC's face-recognition technology in Surat. The algorithm developed by NEC (whose monitors we've always liked) is capable of analysing video feeds in real time, cross referencing those feeds with existing mugshot databases, and triggering an alert when a particular person of interest has been identified.

The fascinating bit was that most of the news items surrounding this announcement were celebratory. And perhaps they should be. The idea of a watchful, all-seeing eye, deterring criminal activity isn't something most people would complain about. I know if my friends or family were kidnapped (for example) I would be very grateful if NeoFace was able to track down the perpetrators and bring my loved ones back to me safe and sound.

Yet, somehow I felt queasy about the whole thing.

In India, we don't have privacy advocacy groups that are vocal enough. In fact, by and large, awareness about privacy issues is pretty low. Many in India would argue that we have better (or worse) things to worry about. But, I cannot let this go. Call me paranoid (or well read) but somehow this theme is all too familiar to me. This is the first step towards making insidious technology a reality – one that that we can, fortunately for now, only see in movies. You guys remember the all-powerful cellphone Sonar from Dark Knight or "God's Eye" from Furious 7 right?

In most developing countries, loss of privacy would be looked at as a necessary if not welcome tradeoff. The argument is that if you have nothing to hide (read: you are not a terrorist) what are you afraid of?

Personally, I'm ok with *something* watching me as I go about performing my mundane daily activities. Despite the risk of the machine get-

ting bored to death, I don't mind this brand of surveillance because a machine is largely infallible (apart from a few statistical false positives of course). However, when such power rests in the hands of a few (corruptible) humans, I'm worried. Systems are never autonomous, in fact they're designed with overrides in place from their very inception. How easy would it be to add the mugshot you see on this page into a criminal database? For now it'll just inconvenience me and Surat will quickly drop to the bottom of my "must-visit" bucket list. But there are far reaching consequences.

At the risk of going Snowden on you, I'll urge you to think of those extrapolations. State-sponsored blackmail, propaganda enforcement, your freedom of movement being restricted – just simply way too much power resting in the hands of the state.

We've been accused of being gloomy in our columns before – particularly Jayesh and I. And at the risk of receiving similar brickbats, I still felt the need to draw the attention of the tech elite of the country (you readers) to this issue. I'm not saying we should go out and hurl rocks at every surveillance camera we see. All I'm saying is we need to appreciate that technology is just a tool. In the right hands, it's a wand of progress and in the wrong ones it could be a weapon of subversion. Our job is to be constantly aware of this. Because only with awareness can we can put pressure on scrutiny and on enforcing audits when these systems are designed. It is our only defence against subversion. If you are signing a deal with the devil you'd better pay attention to the fine print.

Is Surat's implementation of large-scale facial recognition and tracking a step towards progress, or a fall into eventual dystopia? You know where to reach me with your views. Happy reading. 🇮🇳



Siddharth Parwatay
Managing Editor

siddharth.parwatay@digit.in

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A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth Parwatay'.

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editor@digit.in